

BTA ANALYTICS

Industry Intelligence Re- port

Q1 2026

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Contents

Executive Summary	3
The Budtender-Brand Relationship: A Gap Between Experience and Trust	3
On the Floor: Signs of Softening in Retail Advocacy	4
Professional Development & Career Outlook	4
BTA Community Health: Platform Engagement Reaches New Highs	4
Methodology & Data Quality	5

Executive Summary

The cannabis retail landscape is defined by a critical gap between product and brand performance. While products consistently deliver high-quality post-purchase experiences, this satisfaction is not translating into deep-seated brand trust or a frictionless path to purchase. Key industry metrics show **remarkable stability**, with the Experience Quality Index (measuring the overall quality of the purchase and consumption experience) scoring a high 81.7. This is contrasted by a more moderate Brand Trust Index (measuring trust in brand quality, consistency, and communication) of 66.4, indicating that single positive trials are not sufficient to build lasting credibility with frontline staff. This dynamic suggests that for brands, consistency over time is the most critical factor in earning budtender advocacy.

A secondary challenge is emerging on the dispensary floor, where key indicators of budtender engagement are softening. This wave saw modest but notable declines in the Recommendation Conversion Index (a measure **of recommendation effectiveness**, now at 59.1) and the **Interaction Coverage Index** (72.3). **This pattern suggests a potential erosion in the breadth and persuasive power of budtender-customer conversations**, creating an opportunity for brands to reinforce product knowledge and build recommendation confidence.

Separately, turning to the BTA research community itself, engagement has strengthened dramatically, reinforcing the quality of these industry findings. The platform's Net Promoter Score (how likely people are to recommend, on a scale from -100 to +100) saw exceptional wave-over-wave growth, rising 22.1 points to 86.7. This surge indicates that participants see growing value in the community and its resources, which in turn enhances the reliability of the data they provide.

The Budtender-Brand Relationship: A Gap Between Experience and Trust

Budtenders operate as mature, self-reliant consumers, grounding their personal purchasing decisions in direct experience rather than external influence. This cohort's confidence is reflected in their primary information source, with nearly half (47.8%) citing prior experience with a brand, far outweighing peer recommendations (14.9%) or price (11.9%).

The central challenge for brands is that a high-quality product experience does not automatically confer deep brand trust. This disconnect is the most persistent finding this wave, highlighted by the divergence between two key metrics:

- **Experience Quality Index:** 81.7 (High)
- **Brand Trust Index:** 66.4 (Moderate)

This 15.3-point gap suggests that while budtenders are satisfied on a transactional, per-product basis, they maintain a more critical stance on brands themselves. The path to purchase, while not presenting overwhelming barriers, contains related friction. The Choice Friction Index (measuring barriers in the decision process, where a high score is bad) sits at a moderate 56.3, indicating that unresolved complexities in the shopping journey may contribute to this hesitant trust.

For brands and retailers, the key implication is that consistency is the most critical currency. Given that budtenders rely so heavily on their own prior experience, the most effective path to earning their trust and professional recommendation is to build a reliable track record, one predictable product experience at a time.

On the Floor: Signs of Softening in Retail Advocacy

Budtender effectiveness at the point of sale appears to be softening, with key performance metrics showing a modest downturn this wave. The decline suggests a potential erosion in the breadth and persuasive power of budtender-customer conversations, which could impact sales conversion over time.

Both core advocacy metrics are now below their respective all-time averages.

- **Recommendation Conversion Index:** 59.1 (down 4.5 pts)
- **Interaction Coverage Index:** 72.3 (down 4.1 pts)

A potential mechanism for this trend may be emerging from younger workforce cohorts. While the data is directional, it points toward more cautious engagement patterns.

EARLY SIGNAL Among budtenders aged 25 to 34 (N=15-30), there was a noticeable decrease in the frequency of high-volume (50+ interaction) days, coupled with a drop in the proportion who typically provide three recommendations per customer. This may indicate an underlying knowledge or confidence gap; when staff feel less certain, they may naturally narrow their engagement scope.

This pattern signals a potential opportunity for the industry to reinvest in frontline education. Brands may consider deploying targeted training to reinforce product knowledge and build the structured recommendation frameworks needed to convert expertise into confident advocacy.

Professional Development & Career Outlook

A comprehensive assessment of career progression was not possible this period due to sparse data. However, the limited responses available offer an early glimpse into the motivations of a potentially career-oriented segment of the workforce.

EARLY SIGNAL Among a small cohort of respondents (N<15), motivations are shifting toward professionalization and long-term stability within the industry. Factors like “building long-term stability in cannabis retail” and “advocating for positive industry change” are gaining importance as career drivers. This is complemented by a rising interest in developing leadership skills, hinting at a workforce looking for tangible pathways for professional growth.

For industry operators and training providers, these directional findings suggest a latent demand for more structured career development. As the workforce matures, offerings like certifications, leadership training, and clear advancement pathways may become increasingly important tools for attracting and retaining top talent.

BTA Community Health: Platform Engagement Reaches New Highs

Separately, turning to the BTA research community itself, participant engagement and advocacy for the platform have strengthened exceptionally, bolstering the reliability of the industry findings in

this report. **The BTA platform's recommendation score surged across all major segments, signaling that recent enhancements and content are resonating strongly with the professional community.**

The wave-over-wave growth in the platform's Net Promoter Score was dramatic:

- **Overall Community (N=71):** 86.7 (an increase of 22.1 pts)
- **Budtender Cohort (N=31):** 83.9 (an increase of 26.7 pts)
- **Ontario Respondents (N=34):** 84.3 (an increase of 20.3 pts)

This positive momentum is reinforced by a more consistent experience across the community, evidenced by a 4.6-point decrease in the standard deviation of scores.

For industry stakeholders who rely on this research, this strong and growing engagement is a critical signal of data quality. A highly motivated and satisfied research community produces a higher-quality, more reliable signal about the state of the market, lending greater confidence to the insights presented throughout this report.

Methodology & Data Quality

This report draws on survey data collected through the BTA (Budtenders Association) platform from verified, active budtenders. The findings synthesize results from the Spring (workforce and retail focus) and Fall (consumer and brand focus) survey waves.

Confidence Tiers

Metrics in this report are assigned a confidence tier based on the number of respondents (N) for a given segment.

- **High Confidence ($N \geq 30$):** A stable, reportable finding.
- **Directional ($15 \leq N < 30$):** An "Early signal" that should be treated with caution. These findings are always explicitly labeled.
- **Suppressed ($N < 15$):** Data is not reported to maintain quality standards.

Index Definitions

Composite indices are calculated from specific question batteries. Key indices are defined on first use within the report. All scores are on a 0–100 scale unless otherwise noted.

Limitations

The findings reflect the perceptions of BTA-enrolled budtenders and are not necessarily representative of the entire cannabis retail workforce. All data is observational, and no causal inferences should be drawn.

Report Metadata

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 \ **Quality Score:** 1.00 ✓ \ **Suppressed Claims:** 0 \ **Review Status:** Passed automated quality gate \

Generated by the BTA Analytics pipeline. See the Methodology & Controls section for data quality details.